

Thomas Smits

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SUMMARY

I study how visual media have shaped public understanding of the world. My work sits at the intersection of media history, environmental history, and the computational humanities: I use multimodal AI to analyze large historical image collections at a scale that was previously impossible. I am currently using AI to analyze colonial aerial photographs and maps of Indonesia to reconstruct how land was used and transformed under Dutch colonialism.

CURRENT POSITION

Assistant professor of Digital History & AI

Amsterdam School for Historical Studies, University of Amsterdam

November 2023 – present

Amsterdam, NL

PREVIOUS POSITIONS

Postdoc

GOA project. The History of Implicit Bias, University of Antwerp

April 2021 – November 2023

Antwerp, BE

Postdoc

ERC-funded Remembering Activism, Utrecht University

March 2019 – April 2021

Utrecht, NL

EDUCATION

Radboud University

PhD in History

Nijmegen, NL

January 2019

University of Amsterdam

Research Master in History Cum Laude (GPA: 8.5/A+)

Amsterdam, NL

September 2012

PUBLICATIONS (SELECTION)

Books

- Rigney A and Smits T (eds) (2023) *The Visual Memory of Protest*. Amsterdam: AUP.
- Smits T (2020) *The European Illustrated Press and the Emergence of a Transnational Visual Culture of the News, 1842-1870*. London: Routledge

Peer-reviewed articles

- Buelens-Terryn, M., Van Damme, I Smits, T. (2025). Projecting the world. The mediated geography of the projection lantern in Belgium c.1900-c.1920. *Urban History*, FirstView, 1-29.
- Smits. T (2025). (Machine) Learning about the Victorians. *Journal of Victorian Culture*, 30 (4), 304-309.
- Smits. T. et al. (2025). A Fully-Searchable Multimodal Dataset of the Illustrated London News, 1842–1890. *Journal of Open Humanities Data*, 11(10), 1-13.
- Smits, T. (2024). Revisiting the Kahn collection: Multimodal artificial intelligence and visual patterns of presence and absence in the Archives de la Planète, 1909–1931. *Visual Studies*, 0(0), 1-17.
- Smits, T., Wevers, M. (2024). Coloring in the world of others: Color use in visual orientalism, 1890–1920. *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications*, 11(1), 1-8
- Buelens-Terryn, M., Smits, T. (2024). Projecting the world. The mediated geography of the projection lantern in Belgium c.1900-c.1920. *Journal of Historical Geography*, 86, 403-421
- Smit, R., Smits, T., Merrill, S. (2024). Stochastic Remembering and Distributed Mnemonic Agency: Recalling Twentieth Century Activists with ChatGPT. *Memory Studies Review*, 1(aop), 1-22.
- Smits T and Wevers M (2023) A multimodal turn in Digital Humanities? Using contrastive machine learning models to explore, enrich, and analyze digital visual historical collections. *Digital Scholarship in the Humanities*. [DOI](#)
- Smits T and Ros R (2021) Distant reading 940,000 online circulations of 26 iconic photographs. *New Media and Society* 25(12): 3543–3572. [DOI](#).
- Smits T and Ros R (2023) Does transnational contention lead to transnational memory? The online visual memory of the February 2003 anti-Iraq War protests. *Social Movement Studies* 22(1): 23-45. [DOI](#).
- Smits T (2022) A Network of Photographs. The Visual Public Memory of the Dutch Provo Movement, 1967-2016. *Memory Studies* 15(1): 184–203. [DOI](#).
- Smits T and Wevers M (2021) The Agency of Computer Vision Models as Optical Instruments. *Visual Communication* 21(2): 329–349. [DOI](#).
- Wevers M and Smits T (2020) The Visual Digital Turn. Using Neural Networks to Study Historical Images. *Digital Scholarship in the Humanities* 35(1): 194-207 [DOI](#).

- Smits T (2017) Looking for The Illustrated London News in Australian Digital Newspapers. *Media History* 23(1): 80–99. [DOI](#).

Peer-reviewed chapters in books

- Smits. T. (2025) Visual Memory of Protest in the Age of Generative Artificial Intelligence. In: Erll A, Knittel S and Wüstenberg J (eds), *Dynamics, Mediation, Mobilization* Berlin: De Gruyter.
- Smits T and Ros R (2023) Space and place in online visual memory: the Tank Man in Hong Kong, 2013-2020. In: Rigney A and Smits T (eds), *The Visual Memory of Protest* Amsterdam: AUP.
- Smits T (2021) Piracy, Copyright, and the Transnational Trade in Illustrations of News in the Mid-Nineteenth Century,” In: Delamaire M. and Slaughter W (eds), *Circulation and Control: Artistic Culture and Intellectual Property in the Nineteenth Century*. Open Book Publishers. [Link](#).

Peer-reviewed published papers

- Wevers M, T Smits and F Karsdorp (2025) Quantifying Archival Silences: Phylogenetic Diversity Analysis of Controlled Vocabulary Utilization. In: *Anthology of Computers and the Humanities 2025* (eds T Arnold, M Fantoli, and R Ros) pp. 266-279.
- Smits, T, W Haverals, L Verreyen, M Allart and Kestemont M (2023) Greetings From! Extracting Address Information From 100,000 Historical Picture Postcards. In: *Proceedings of the Conference on Computational Humanities Research 2023* (eds A. ŠeĽa, F. Jannidis, I Romanowska)pp. 512-529. EUR-WS. [Link](#).
- Smits T and Kestemont M (2021) Towards Multimodal Computational Humanities. Using CLIP to Analyze Late-Nineteenth Century Magic Lantern Slides. In: *Proceedings of the Conference on Computational Humanities Research 2021* (eds M Ehrmann, F Karsdorp, M Wevers, et al.)pp. 149–158. CEUR-WS. [Link](#).
- Wevers M and Smits T (2020) Detecting Faces, Visual Medium Types, and Gender in Historical Advertisements, 1950–1995. In: *Computer Vision – ECCV 2020 Workshops* (eds A Bartoli and A Fusiello), Cham, 2020, pp. 77–91. Springer International Publishing.
- Smits T and Ros R (2020) Quantifying Iconicity in 940K Online Circulations of 26 Iconic Photographs. In: *Proceedings of the Workshop on Computational Humanities Research 2020* (eds F Karsdorp, B McGillivray, A Nerghes, et al.)pp. 375–384. CEUR-WS. [Link](#).

Peer-reviewed lessons/tutorials

- Van Strien D, Beelen K, Wevers M, Smits T and McDonough K (2022) Computer Vision for the Humanities: An Introduction to Deep Learning for Image Classification (Part 1 and Part 2) *Programming Historian*. [DOI](#)

GRANTS

- (2026) UvA Faculty of Humanities Individual Talent Fund, ”Uncharted: How Indigenous Knowledge Made Environmental Change Visible in Colonial Indonesia, 1864-1939.” (extra research time, 0.2 fte 6 month).
- (2026) UvA Sustainability Platform, ”Using AI and Colonial Maps to Reconstruct Tropical Forest Loss in the Pre-Satellite Era” (€50,000).
- (2026) NWO Open Competition XS, ”Terraforming from Above: Digital Methods for Colonial Aerial Photography” (€50,000).
- (2023) Research Society for Victorian Periodicals Field Development Grant 2023: ”Distant Viewing the Illustrated Worlds of the Nineteenth Century” (with Paul Fyfe and Ben Lee) (\$23.000)
- (2019) Grant to support Research in Residence position at the Centre for Spatial and Textual Analysis (CESTA), Stanford. (\$1800)

PRIZES

- (2020) Colby Book Prize for *The European Illustrated Press* (\$2000).

PHD STUDENTS AND JUNIOR RESEARCHERS

- PhD: Loren Verreyen, ’Distant Listening: Fictionality in True Crime Podcasts’ (UvA/UA).
- PhD: Aijia Zhong, ’Computational investigation of lianhuahua’ (Heidelberg).
- PhD (Completed): Eleonora Paklons, ’Dream particles of modernity: the magic lantern and the representation of place, 1880–1939’ (UA).
- JR: (Completed) Beth Warner, ’Multimodal AI, Image Analysis, and the Illustrated Periodical Press’ (UvA).

LANGUAGES/CODE/TOOLS

Languages: Dutch (native), English (fluent), German (proficient).

Code/ML: Python, PyTorch, Scikit-learn, NumPy, Pandas, Git.